

Rev. 22:16-21
Come Lord Jesus!

Introduction:

Too often in life, things that are or will be subjectively real (as actual things, impending things, things imminently awaiting such as are really about to happen) are thought of in the abstract and surreal terms (as if bizarre, unreal and far off)

And of course, depending on which way we view a thing—as abstract and surreal or subjectively real—we will live accordingly!

Growing up, it was referred to as “living in la la land”

I heard it most in my teenage years—when I thought I knew enough not to listen to anyone, but my life experience was such as to have too little real consequences yet such as to fear much of anything, or believe much of anything that I’m told as pertaining to the real and imminent things of life that need diligent preparations...

*And so, my question to you today is this (regardless of your age)-
- Are you living in “la la land” as it pertains to the second coming of Christ?*

Regardless of your age today—have you naively, if not conveniently, put aside as abstract and surreal that you will die, that you will face a judgment, that you will encounter the return of Christ and one of two realities that he will establish at that time?

In today’s passage, we will discover basically this one message from God—it is a message as concerns the subjectively real thing of Christ’s return, even as it is expressed as to impress us with its reality!

Listen then to the last words of the holy scripture given to us by God. Listen especially to the tone of these words, a tone not fitting contemplations of something abstract and surreal, but subjectively actual and real-- as then attached to the content as concerning the imminent and actual coming of Christ for the second and last time!

Text:

Rev. 22:16

“It is I, Jesus, who sent my angel to you with this testimony for the churches. I am the root and the descendant of David, the bright morning star.”

17 The Spirit and the bride say, “**Come.**”
And let everyone who hears say, “**Come.**”
And let everyone who is thirsty **come.**

Let anyone who wishes take the water of life as a gift.

Rev. 22:18

I warn everyone who hears the words of the prophecy of this book: if anyone adds to them, God will add to that person the plagues described in this book; **19** if anyone takes away from the words of the book of this prophecy, God will take away that person’s share in the tree of life and in the holy city, which are described in this book.

Rev. 22:20

The one who testifies to these things says, “**Surely I am coming soon.**”

Amen. **Come,** Lord Jesus!

Exposition:

Today we conclude a 6 week advent series—thinking about the coming of Christ.

1st 4 sermons focused upon Christ’s first coming—and especially, who it was that came in the person of Christ some 2000 years past as then to accomplish a long expected salvation of God’s chosen people!

These 1st four weeks were devoted to understanding the coming of Christ the coming of a priest, prophet and king

TOGETHER with the expectations of salvation that were associated with each of these roles...

And yet, as wonderful and significant as Christ's coming was—Christ himself warned that the “joy of man's desire” as related to the expectations for the complete restoration of a chosen humanity to Eden would not yet be completed in his coming, speaking then of a return visit wherein these expectations would actually be fulfilled!

Christ further warned that the times between his coming would be difficult times for the elect—times wherein those who are already saved by God's grace and those already adopted as God's son's and daughters would be persecuted from without, tempted from within as those who are both in the world and yet called to be not of the world.

In other words, when Christ ascended into heaven and left behind a world that still suffered under the context where *might was not yet right!*

- ✓ The might of nature still under God's curse continues to prevail in sickness and in death...
- ✓ The might of human nature still under God's curse continues to *when a person is tempted by one's own desire, being lured and enticed by it; such as to gives birth to sin, such as to gives birth to evil and death.*
- ✓ The might of governments, even good governments, as not sufficient to stop injustice and wars...
- ✓ The might of economies such as to reward selfishness and greed rather than benevolence and good will...

To be sure, might is not yet right this side of the ascension of Christ into heaven!

Even while the kingdom has come, and the Holy Spirit is present like never before to evangelize and convert the nations to God—even as the gospel has been granted unprecedented power and success after the ascension of Christ, as compared to the

whole of history prior to the ascension of Christ... even as God has protected his church such as to withstand even the armies of Satan that would be march through the gates of hell... even with all of this, Christ warned and the early church quickly discovered that the kingdom of God was not yet complete—awaiting then a final and cataclysmic revisitation of Christ for the second and last time!

IT was therefore concerning the days between the comings that our 5th advent was focused-- called “last days”—the last days are our days—and we saw how these days are characterized by an increase in self-love, even as this misplaced love is the ultimate cause of the suffering and temptation that we continue to experience—it is self-love that results in the persecution and suffering for those who belong, and live like they belong, to Christ.

Our sermon context brings us then to the context of our passage as well..

Revelations is all about the last days, days wherein the kingdom of God has come, even as it remains in the midst of the kingdoms of this world ...

As then in the immediate context of our passage, John is concerned to inform those living in the “between days” that times will call for perseverance---

E.g. His last message is basically an exhortation to ***Keep the Faith in the light of Christ's coming again!***

Rev. 22:7

“See, I am coming soon! Blessed is the one who **keeps** the words of the prophecy of this book.”

Concerning the present reality of the two competing kingdoms:

11 Let the evildoer still do evil, and the filthy still be filthy, and the righteous still do right, and the holy still be holy.”

Rev. 22:12

"See, I am coming soon; my reward is with me, to repay according to everyone's work.

Vs. 16ff...

Notice:

1—the teachings of the book are witnessed by Christ himself as the last words that will be given

"It is I, Jesus, who sent my angel to you with this testimony for the churches.

Rev. 22:18

I warn everyone who hears the words of the prophecy of this book: if anyone adds to them, God will add to that person the plagues described in this book; **19** if anyone takes away from the words of the book of this prophecy, God will take away that person's share in the tree of life and in the holy city, which are described in this book.

2—the tone is emphatically urgent, as about things that are subjectively real vs. abstract and surreal!

The emphatic language of the divine indicative!

I am coming soon!... I am coming soon!... Surely, I am coming soon!

God's last words—I am coming soon—

These are the words that he want to leave us with—the last words of a long history of words beginning thousands of years before in the words pertaining to the history of the world even, its fall, the many subsequent visitation that brought forth a redemptive promise and plan... all of which were to prepare the world for these final words as pertaining to the visitation of Christ for the last time!

3—The response of the church is portrayed as the response of all true and faithful believers living in the last days...

The divine indicatives are met by the response of the church—that cries out, "come"

It is this response that the book of revelations seeks to evoke!

Notice as well, that it is a response that is rooted in the expectations that the faithful have had for the visitation of God throughout the centuries and millennia of redemptive history!

The tone is desperate as then filled with the hope of man's desire... it is the advent disposition that ought to characterize the church militant—the church that exists in the between days—a disposition that if only one short sentence could be used to describe it, the sentence would be "come lord Jesus." It is a conviction resulting in a posturer that reflects the church's deep desire for a complete fulfillment of the messianic prophecies whereby man's desire will be fully satisfied. These promises are now identified with Jesus

For if the first advent began a good work, the Christian is all the more desirous for the work to be accomplished!

And again, it is especially important to recognize from our passage is that this advent posture is identified with the posture that pervaded all of redemptive history.. e.g.

Our passage makes use of OT passages that especially spoke to the desire for God to come and bring in his new creation Kingdom—

Notice for instance:

1. **How it is that Jesus is identified**—as to be identified with the coming of David and all the hopes and promises attached to this as was the focus of our second advent sermon this season in so far as in the coming of Jesus was the coming of the one

who would bring in a perfect kingdom of peace and prosperity as was promised to David via his incorruptible descendant!

I am the root and the descendant of David, the bright morning star."

Titles combine two OT prophecies--

Num. 24:17 I see him, but not now; I behold him, but not near-- a star shall come out of Jacob, and a scepter shall rise out of Israel; it shall crush the borderlands of Moab, and the territory of all the Shethites.

Is. 11:1 ¶ A shoot shall come out from the stump of Jesse, and a branch shall grow out of his roots. **Is. 11:10** On that day the root of Jesse shall stand as a signal to the peoples; the nations shall inquire of him, and his dwelling shall be glorious.

Together, these passages both identify the messiah and what the messiah would ultimately accomplish...

But especially, it identifies the messiah as the longing over every human heart...

Notice especially

Both OT references concern the messianic king's triumph over his enemies at the end of time and the re-gathering of God's people into a great and everlasting kingdom.

The fact that Jesus has already begun to fulfill these prophecies is confirmed by the use of these two prophetic names in relation to Jesus' resurrection in 5:5-7 and 2:27-28), *and yet the emphasis here on advent accentuates the church's desire that He come and complete what is begun.* ...

According to these passages,

On this new day, a great King would come and re-assemble all the true people God together into one kingdom where they will reign over all the earth, where there will be immeasurable prosperity and protection as from the steady and everlasting rule of the great king!

Is. 11:11

¶ On that day the Lord will extend his hand yet a second time to recover the remnant that is left of his people, from Assyria, from Egypt, from Pathros, from Ethiopia, from Elam, from Shinar, from Hamath, and from the coastlands of the sea. **12** He will raise a signal for the nations, and will assemble the outcasts of Israel, and gather the dispersed of Judah from the four corners of the earth. ... **16** so there shall be a highway from Assyria for the remnant that is left of his people, as there was for Israel when they came up from the land of Egypt.

Note then the expectations include that this messiah will be the one arising to rule over the nations (gentiles) (c.f. Rom. 15:12)

Is. 55, "arise and shine for your light has come... nations will come to your light and kings to the brightness of your rising." ... thus this serves to highlight Jesus as the one to whom the nations come for salvation...

New day-- as associated with "bright morning star"-- Christ has begun a new redemptive day, which will culminate at his final return...

Thus,

2 Peter 1:17-19 where the morning star is synonymous with the dawning day both possibly metaphors for the inauguration of the OT prophetic word in Christ' first coming...

The Point: That what Christ has begun is nothing less than a fulfillment of all the expectations and desires associated with the promises made to David—expectations that one day, the people of God would be perfectly restored in his presence such as to be brought to a place of Eden again, albeit where there is no possibility of ever losing it again...

And again, the emphasis of our passage is to recall of this in order to evoke the faithful response "come Lord Jesus" even Christians are to live into this response as those who really do expect the return of Christ and who then order their priorities accordingly!

In short—the question our passage would have us to ask whenever we do anything is this:

Would this thought, action, priority, rule be in keeping with Christ return and what I will expect to happen when he does?

It of course raises the question as to what we do expect will happen when Christ returns—even as our passage, in reference to the whole of prophecy, means to assume that the reader is aware of this!

By way of a quick review:

1. The Manner of Christ second coming:

- ✓ Personal, physical/visible
Acts 1:11 They said, "Men of Galilee, why do you stand looking up toward heaven? This Jesus, who has been taken up from you into heaven, will come in the same way as you saw him go into heaven."
Rev. 1:7 Look! He is coming with the clouds; every eye will see him, even those who pierced him; and on his account all the tribes of the earth will wail. So it is to be. Amen
- ✓ Sudden, without warning,
Mark 13:32 But of that day and hour no one knows, not even the angels in heaven, nor the Son, but only the Father.
- ✓ Cateclysmic
2Pet. 3:10 But the day of the Lord will come like a thief, and then the heavens will pass away with a loud noise, and the elements will be dissolved with fire, and the earth and everything that is done on it will be disclosed

2. The Actions of Christ's second coming:

- ✓ Render a final and complete Judgement

Complete—as to cover everything done and said!

2Cor. 5:10 For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ, that each one may receive the things done in the body, according to what he has done, whether good or bad.

Rom. 2:16 in the day when God will judge the secrets of men by Jesus Christ, according to my gospel.

Matt. 12:36 But I say to you that for every idle word men may speak, they will give account of it in the day of judgment. 37 For by your words you will be justified, and by your words you will be condemned.

Judgement then will either be with or without Christ as our advocate: e.g. notice in 2Th. How this is related to the gospel...

2Th. 1:7 and to give you who are troubled rest with us when the Lord Jesus is revealed from heaven with His mighty angels, 8 in flaming fire taking vengeance on those who do not know God, and on those who do not obey the gospel of our Lord Jesus Christ. 9 These shall be punished with everlasting destruction from the presence of the Lord and from the glory of His power, 10 when He comes, in that Day, to be glorified in His saints and to be admired among all those who believe, because our testimony among you was believed

E.g. those without Christ, will be judged for their own deeds, every one of them—those with Christ, their deeds will be judged according to the work of Christ!

- ✓ Establish an everlasting kingdom after the type of Eden according to the expectation of old!

See then Rev.

Rev. 22:1

Then the angel showed me the river of the water of life, bright as crystal, flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb 2 through the middle of the street of the city. On either side of the river is the tree of life with its twelve kinds of fruit, producing its fruit each month; and the leaves of the tree are for the healing of the nations. 3 Nothing accursed will be found there any more. But the throne of God and of the Lamb will be in it, and his servants will worship him; 4 they will see his face, and his name will be on their foreheads. 5 And there will be no more night; they need no light of lamp or sun, for the Lord God will be their light, and they will reign forever and ever.

See then: (again a review)

2Sam. 7: 5 Go and tell my servant David: Thus says the LORD:... I will make for you a great name, like the name of the great ones of the earth. 10 And I will appoint a place for my people Israel and will plant them, so that they may live in their own place, and be disturbed no more; and evildoers shall afflict them no more, as formerly, 11 from the time that I appointed judges over my people Israel; and I will give you rest from all your enemies. Moreover the LORD declares to you that the LORD will make you a house. 12 When your days are

fulfilled and you lie down with your ancestors, I will raise up your offspring after you, who shall come forth from your body, and I will establish his kingdom. 13 He shall build a house for my name, and I will establish the throne of his kingdom forever. 14 I will be a father to him, and he shall be a son to me. When he commits iniquity, I will punish him with a rod such as mortals use, with blows inflicted by human beings. 15 But I will not take my steadfast love from him, as I took it from Saul, whom I put away from before you. 16 Your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me; your throne shall be established forever. 17 In accordance with all these words and with all this vision, Nathan spoke to David.

Great themes:

1. A Place:

10 And I will appoint a place for my people Israel and will plant them, so that they may live in their own place.

John 14:2

In my Father's house there are many dwelling places. If it were not so, would I have told you that I go to prepare a place for you? 3 And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again and will take you to myself, so that where I am, there you may be also.

2. It is a place of absolute and perfect happiness under the rule of a perfect and benevolent ruler..

and be disturbed no more; and evildoers shall afflict them no more,

Is.9:5-6 (God's promise to David in 2 Samuel is reiterated)

For a child has been born for us, a son given to us, authority rests upon his shoulders and he is named wonderful counselor, mighty God, everlasting father, prince of peace. His authority shall extend continually and there shall be endless peace for the throne of David and his kingdom.

3. An everlasting kingdom with God present at all times.. (as represented by their living amidst God's house...

13 He shall build a house for my name, and I will establish the throne of his kingdom forever...16 Your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me; your throne shall be established forever.

This then is what Christ will accomplished—which again explains what it is that the faithful so desire—

**Justice
Salvation
Place**

The tone is desperate as then filled with the hope of man's desire...

This is also taken from OT prophecy, as in

Is. 55:1 Ho, everyone who thirsts, come to the waters; and you that have no money, come, buy and eat! Come, buy wine and milk without money and without price.

But what is especially noteworthy from Isaiah is how the prophet identifies the people's thirst as that which can only be satisfied in God's messiah as identified with David, even though they attempt to find satisfaction in various worldly ways.

2 Why do you spend your money for that which is not bread, and your labor for that which does not satisfy?

Listen carefully to me, and eat what is good, and delight yourselves in rich food. 3 Incline your ear, and come to me; listen, so that you may live. I will make with you an everlasting covenant, my steadfast, sure love for David.

The prophet then promises that when the messiah comes, he will be a leader/ruler for those who will be gathered from every nation:

4 See, I made him a witness to the peoples, a leader and commander for the peoples. 5 See, you shall call nations that you do not know, and nations that do not know you shall run to you, because of the LORD your God, the Holy One of Israel, for he has glorified you.

This complete satisfaction with a life of abundance will result in a life of complete joy and peace... such that the people of God will be found bursting out in song even as all of creation will join them in the joyous procession to God in worship!

Is. 55:12

¶ For you shall go out in joy, and be led back in peace; the mountains and the hills before you shall burst into song, and all the trees of the field shall clap their hands. 13 Instead of the thorn shall come up the cypress; instead of the brier shall come up the myrtle; and it shall be to the LORD for a memorial, for an everlasting sign that shall not be cut off.

All of these incredible expectations as related to the complete and ultimate satisfaction of man's desire as fulfilled in David are then what Christ meant to identify himself with, for instance in

John 6:35 Jesus said to them, "I am the bread of life. Whoever comes to me will never be hungry, and whoever believes in me will never be thirsty.
John 7:37 ¶ On the last day of the festival, the great day, while Jesus was standing there, he cried out, "Let anyone who is thirsty come to me,

So then, John has already identified the coming of Christ with the complete satisfaction of man's desire:

Rev. 21:6 Then he said to me, "It is done! I am the Alpha and the Omega, the beginning and the end. To the thirsty I will give water as a gift from the spring of the water of life.

And the church of the faithful cry out "come Lord Jesus"

Application:

- Are you living in "la la land" as it pertains to the second coming of Christ?

Regardless of your age today—have you naively, if not conveniently, put aside as abstract and surreal that you will die, that you will face a judgment, that you will encounter the return of Christ and one of two realities that he will establish at that time?

In today's passage, we discover basically this one message from God—it is a message as concerns the subjectively real thing of Christ's return, even as it is expressed as to impress us with its reality!

We have heard and considered the last words of the holy scripture given to us by God.

The tone is urgent, as pertaining to something as real and imminent as anything you could ever prepare for, but with far greater consequence that anything you could ever prepare for..

Listen especially to the tone of these words, as then attached to the content as concerning the imminent and actual coming of Christ for the second and last time!

Illustration: Death of Ivan Ilych

Death of Ivan Ilych by Leo Tolstoy

Chapter 6

Ivan Ilych saw that he was dying, and he was in continual despair.

In the depth of his heart he knew he was dying, but not only was he not accustomed to the thought, he simply did not and could not grasp it.

The syllogism he had learnt from Kiesewetter's Logic: "Caius is a man, men are mortal, therefore Caius is mortal," had always seemed to him correct as applied to Caius, but certainly not as applied to himself. That Caius -- man in the abstract -- was mortal, was perfectly correct, but he was not Caius, not an abstract man, but a creature quite, quite separate from all others.

And to replace that thought he called up a succession of others, hoping to find in them some support. He tried to get back into the former current of thoughts that had once screened the thought of death from him. But strange to say, all that had formerly shut off, hidden, and destroyed his consciousness of death, no longer had that effect. Ivan Ilych now spent most of his time in attempting to re-establish that old current. He would say to himself: "I will take up my duties again -- after all I used to live by them." And banishing all doubts he would go to the law courts, enter into conversation with his colleagues, and sit carelessly as was his wont, scanning the crowd with a thoughtful look and leaning both his emaciated arms on the arms of his oak chair; bending over as usual to a colleague and drawing his papers nearer he would interchange whispers with him, and then suddenly raising his eyes and sitting erect would pronounce certain words and open the proceedings. But suddenly in the midst of those proceedings the pain in his side, regardless of the stage the proceedings had reached, would begin its own gnawing work. Ivan Ilych would turn his attention to it and try to drive the thought of it away, but without success. *It* would come and stand before him and look at him, and he would be petrified and the light would die out of his eyes, and he would again begin asking himself whether *It* alone was true.

Pictures of his past rose before him one after another. they always began with what was nearest in time and then went back to what was most remote -- to his childhood -- and rested there. If he thought of the stewed prunes that had been offered him that day, his mind went back to the raw shrivelled French plums of his childhood, their peculiar flavour and the flow of saliva when he sucked their stones, and along with the memory of that taste came a whole series of memories of those days: his nurse, his brother, and their toys. "No, I mustn't think of that....It is too painful," Ivan Ilych said to himself, and brought himself back to the present -- to the button on the back of the sofa and the creases in its morocco. "Morocco is expensive, but it does not wear well: there had been a quarrel about it. It was a different kind of quarrel and a different kind of morocco that time when we tore father's portfolio and were punished, and mamma brought us some tarts...." And again his thoughts dwelt on his childhood, and again it was painful and he tried to banish them and fix his mind on something else.

Then again together with that chain of memories another series passed through his mind -- of how his illness had progressed and grown worse. There also the further back he looked the more life there had been. There had been more of what was good in life and more of life itself. The two merged together. "Just as the pain went on getting worse and worse, so my life grew worse and worse," he thought. "There is one bright spot there at the back, at the beginning of life, and afterwards all becomes blacker and blacker and proceeds more and more rapidly -- in inverse ratio to the square of the distance from death," thought Ivan Ilych. And the example of a stone falling downwards with increasing velocity entered his mind. Life, a series of increasing sufferings, flies further and further towards its end -- the most terrible suffering. "I am flying...." He shuddered, shifted himself, and tried to resist, but was already aware that resistance was impossible, and again with eyes weary of gazing but unable to cease seeing what was before them, he stared at the back of the sofa and waited -- awaiting that dreadful fall and shock and destruction.

"Resistance is impossible!" he said to himself. "If I could only understand what it is all for! But that too is impossible. An explanation would be possible if it could be said that I have not lived as I ought to. But it is impossible to say that," and he remembered all the legality, correctitude, and propriety of his life. "That at any rate can certainly not be admitted," he thought, and his lips smiled ironically as if someone could see that smile and be taken in by it. "There is no explanation! Agony, death....What for?"

Abstract surreal (unreal) vs. subjective real actual...

2. Why should we desire the 2nd coming of Christ?

Is it that we hate this world? NO!

It is that we love this world, and hate that it has been so perverted and spoiled?

It is that we love life, love people, love all the good things that make for creation—as God pronounced all things good at his making—that drives us to cry out "come"...

If you like creation—then you will love the 2nd coming of Christ—when creation will be restored!

Rev. 22:1

Then the angel showed me the river of the water of life, bright as crystal, flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb 2 through the middle of the street of the city. On either side of the river is the tree of life with its twelve kinds of fruit, producing its fruit each month; and the leaves of the tree are for the healing of the nations. 3 Nothing accursed will be found there any more. But the throne of God and of the Lamb will be in it, and his servants will worship him; 4 they will see his face, and his name will be on their foreheads. 5 And there will be no more night; they need no light of lamp or sun, for the Lord God will be their light, and they will reign forever and ever.

E.g. Eden restored!

Rom 8:19 For the creation waits with eager longing for the revealing of the children of God; 20 for the creation was subjected to futility, not of its own will but by the will of the one who subjected it, in hope 21 that the creation itself will be set free from its bondage to decay and will obtain the freedom of the glory of the children of God. 22 We know that the whole creation has been groaning in labor pains until now;

Is it that we hate our work? NO—it is that we love and desire the noble dream that moves us to work—that makes us to cry out Come Lord Jesus..

It is the fact that in spite of the very best efforts of human ingenuity and work—that might still is not right!!!

While we rightly esteem the noble efforts reflected in human vocation to make things right—eventually, we discover over and over again that the might is not yet right—in that not matter how we try, this world still succumbs to evil, it still suffers under the

Think about this for a minute:
What we can't do in our best of labors the gospel can...

Noble dream of medicine: the might of cursed nature will eventually prevail, no matter how much we might delay it and/or ease its pain!

Noble dream of law: the might of cursed society will eventually prevail, no matter how many law we make and try to enforce, no matter how large our police force may curb it... cheating, lying, killing, stealing, bribing, dishonest gain—no-one can escape being touched by these things eventually!

Noble dream of parenting: the might of cursed human nature will eventually prevail—no matter how much we try to teach good morals, our little ones will grow up and hurt someone by their words and/or actions--

Noble dream of home making: the might of a cursed life will eventually prevail, in that our homes will never be beautiful enough or secure enough or ordered enough to be the haven we long to make...

Noble dream of art:

Noble dream of entertainment:

The fact remains—that since the ascension of Christ into heaven—we still suffer in a context where might is not right!

E.g. We work ourselves to the bone and for what—to bring about a restoration of health, justice, social happiness, home, laughter/joy, etc... only to discover that at our very best—we can do these things provisionally and inadequately...

And so, for those who do belong to God, for those who are established in the above two convictions—convictions that Christ's return IS real and imminent together with the conviction that only Christ's return can and will reestablish might that is right wherein we will be planted in a

kingdom of no distress, no injustice, no sickness or death even a kingdom that will have no end...

Then we discern and begin ourselves to live out the reality of our hearts desire—saying "Come Lord Jesus"

And who then would this change our living?

If we are Christians:

1. We would believe more in those things that have been given to us now for the sake of tapping into God's might—we would long more for the instruments and power that is given to us by prayer, word, sacraments, fellowship, witness and gospel... , we would be loath to abandon these things for whatever other vocations we are given, knowing that ultimately, it is these things, as they stay our hope on Christ and his coming again, that will bring about the heaven we all long to establish by but are frustrated in establishing by our human might.
2. We would in short, value more the gospel as it pertains to the coming of Christ, and value less all the things of this world, as good as they may be, impotent to overcome the might that is not right!
3. We would have priorities that really do live as if Christ is returning—priorities concerning what we want to teach our children—think about it, what if we put half as much effort into teaching our children the Christian faith as we do in preparing them for the next human exam—(Illustration—SAT prep...)

In other words, even for those who are in Christ, there is STILL the temptation to satisfy our thirst with things other than Christ. We are still very thirsty aren't we... as this often drives us to wells that are not of God's making, wells that are polluted and will ultimately have the adverse affect upon us as we where hoping..

Illus. This has been wonderfully illustrated by David Myers in his book entitled "The American Paradox, Spiritual Hunger in an Age of Plenty"

What Myers did was observe how so many of the things often associated with the "American dream" have NOT brought us the happiness we have thought it would.

He illustrates this by taking a closer look at the happiness index as related then to the sexual revolution, individualism, material prosperity, etc. What he shows is how the very things that we often thought would bring us happiness have brought us misery... He asks:

Has the historical pendulum swung to a point where the pursuit of pleasure is ironically amplifying misery?

In countless examples, he answer through his research with a resounding "yes".

If you are not a Christian:

1. The good news is that God understand your hunger—it is not wrong that you hunger and thirst, even as this will drive you to all sorts of work and play... but also know that all the work, all the accomplishments, all the relationships, houses, children, spouses—all the things of this world—as good as they may be—will not satisfy your cravings!—only Christ's return will do this for those who belong to him...

Therefore, before you turn to the doctor, turn to Christ- for what a doctor can't do the coming of Christ can... that is conquer all disease and sickness, even death itself...

Before you turn to that lawyer or policeman—turn to Christ—for What the lawyer/policeman can't do the coming of Chris can—that is establish and bring about justice, fairness, equity, protection from bad things, preservation in good things...

What the parent can't do the coming of Christ can—turn children's hearts to their parents and parents to their children, making people into productive and happy people...

What a homemaker can't do, the coming of Christ can—provide a place of belonging that will never be taken away...

What an entertainer can't do, the coming of Christ can—take us away from the monotony of an opaque and pale life to the vibrancy of life...

The spirit of advent cries out for Christ's coming, even as it puts into perspective all the work of our hands, as only provisionally valuable in so far as it prepares the way of Christ 's coming...

How much do you love the appearing of Christ... 1Tim.4)

8 in the future there is laid up for me the crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous Judge, will award to me on that day; and not only to me, but also to all who have loved His appearing.

IN sum, even if we were to gain all the prosperity and protection that this world has to offer, we are still insatiably hungry, which is why we are called by this text to live everyday in the spirit of "advent"-- which places our insatiable appetite for life in the coming of Christ rather than in the prosperity of this world...

Clearly then, the lesson of "advent" is that our soul's longing is to be satisfied only in the coming of Christ, and not by anything we can gain by worldly prosperity and/or protection...

And yet, the longing of our hearts ought to swell up with the cry Come Lord Jesus...

His coming is perfectly revealed at this table as representing the satisfying our our deepest hunger-- hunger as then statisfied to our eating and drinking of his body and blood

John 6:35

¶ Jesus said to them, "I am the bread of life. **Whoever** comes to me will never be hungry, and **whoever** believes in me will never be thirsty.

Let us then cry out "come Lord Jesus"

Let us even now be prepared to receive him at his table.. here provided for us until he comes...